

DELHI An old communist knows what a bear hug is all about and trust a Maoist to be even better at it. That is what Prime Minister Manmohan Singh discovered on September 15 when he met the new prime minister of Nepal Pushpa Kamal Dahal alias Prachanda. While the atmospherics were good, Prachanda talked about a "fresh start for the Nepal-India relations" during their parleys. This was the first meeting between the two premiers since the Maoist formed the government in Nepal last month.

Prachanda was candid as he told Manmohan that "relations with India are crucial for Nepal". Manmohan responded that India's commitment to the development of Nepal will continue. The message was clear that Delhi was willing to do business with his government. "I am going back to Nepal satisfied. I will tell Nepali citizens that a new

Comrades in Arms

YASBANT NEGI

FRESH START:
Manmohan (left)
with Prachanda



era has dawned," Prachanda said as he wrapped up his visit.

For many in South Block still living in a time warp, Prachanda came across as someone who

could deliver. Their meeting also provided an opportunity to clear the air on both sides. The Maoist proved that they were not trying to play China against India while

India showed that it respected the verdict of the people and its traditional friendship with the Nepali Congress would not come in the way of supporting the Maoist regime.

Delhi is also open to a review of the 1950 friendship treaty. India raised the issue of an extradition treaty, which has been on the backburner. Insiders say that when India raised its security concerns about Nepal becoming a haven for anti-India terror groups, especially for the Pakistani intelligence agency ISI, Prachanda promised to act tough.

There was progress on vexed water resources issues as both agreed to set up a ministerial committee to discuss the Kosi treaty and find solutions to avert calamities like the devastating Bihar floods. While their first meeting was about making a fresh impression, at least a new beginning has been made.

by Saurabh Shukla

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

L.K. Advani wants the party to announce chief ministerial candidates for all the coming assembly polls, reopening speculation about Delhi. The contenders are Arun Jaitley, V.K. Malhotra, Harsh Vardhan and Vijay Goel.

VOICES

"I am working for the image and branding of Gujarat. I don't have time to think about my own image."

Narendra Modi, Gujarat chief minister

"Blasts are not a cricket match where I should give you running commentary. Whatever is shared between Gujarat police and us is confidential and should not be revealed."

Y.S. Dadwal, Delhi Police commissioner

"It is very easy under our system to delay trials in India because the accused challenges every order of the trial court in the high court and fights it up to the Supreme Court."

K.G. Balakrishnan, Chief Justice of India

"If the country considers it is necessary to conduct nuclear tests, it can do so. Nothing stops us. We are entitled to carry out nuclear tests if it is found necessary."

Pranab Mukherjee, external affairs minister

"I don't think relations between India and Australia were damaged permanently due to the (racism) incident. The IPL came at the right time to ensure that ties were mended."

Adam Gilchrist, Australian cricketer